



Greener Arctic

With the help of drones scientists have discovered that the Arctic is getting greener.
<https://digit.in/mar20-25>



AI Security Drone System

Sunflower labs' AI security system uses sensors to provide 24/7 autonomous drone surveillance. <https://digit.in/mar20-26>



DRONE PILOT

A nascent field, finally taking off

Dhriti Datta | dhriti@digit.in

E

ver since their inception, drones, also known as Remotely Piloted Aerial Systems (RPAs) or Unmanned

Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), have had a rather tumultuous journey plagued with security concerns, especially in India. In the year 2014, the Indian government imposed an unanticipated blanket ban on the use of civil drones. This sudden decision was the aftermath of an incident where Pizzeria, a Mumbai-based restaurant, attempted to use a drone to air-drop pizzas in the vicinity. A rather knee-jerk reaction, wouldn't you say? Nevertheless, this decision effectively set our country's drone industry back by several years, while the opportunity was efficaciously monetised by China.

Four years later, the Indian government recognised the blanket ban as impractical since drones could easily be imported by civilians through both online and offline platforms as toys. On December 1, 2018, the Indian government came up with a regulatory policy regarding drones which effectively lifted the blanket ban. Regardless of this ban in India and issues abroad, the

drone industry continued to grow at an unprecedented rate of over 40 per cent year-on-year. This rapidly emerging technology spawned multiple startups in the drone sector which made a career as a drone pilot reality instead of just being a fantasy.

DRONE REGULATORY POLICY

In order to successfully (and might we add, legally) pursue a career as a drone pilot, you must be well-versed with the regulatory policy surrounding piloting commercial drones in India. The policy came to effect in 2018 when the DGCA (Directorate General of Civil Aviation) announced the release of its Civil Aviation Regulations (CAR) to ensure safe usage and flight of UAVs in India.

Firstly, the policy classified drones in different categories based on their

weight. The categories include – Nano drones (up to 250 gms), Micro drones (250 gms – 2 kg), Small drones (2 kg – 25 kg), Medium drones (25 kg – 150 kg) and lastly, Large drones (anything higher than 150 kg). Under this policy, all drone sizes apart from Nano drones, are required to be registered by the pilot/operator on the Digital Sky Platform. Therefore, civilians can no longer simply buy any drone and fly it. They are required to follow a lengthy list of compliances. The Digital Sky Platform is a platform which allows the Indian government to control commercial usage of drones with national Unmanned Traffic Management (UTM). India also has an NPNT (No Permission – No Takeoff) clause which prohibits drones (micro and above) from flying unless they have been given regulatory permission. Nevertheless, as per the DGCA, only a mere four companies are NPNT compliant, meaning there are plenty of drone manufacturers selling in India, both online and offline, who fail to even mention NPNT on their products.

Apart from this, pilots/operators require an Unmanned Aerial Operator's Permit (UAOP) or a Remote Pilot License which costs around ₹25,000.



A Nano Drone requires no registration under the new regulatory policy for drones in India.